










that science and technology must serve neglected public health challenges, it identifies gaps within public healthcare systems and supports tools that make diagnosis faster, surveillance smarter and care more accessible.

It is individuals and institutions like India Health Fund that this Republic Day special issue of INDIA TODAY celebrates. These are the Gems of India, solving problems where they are the most entrenched and the outcomes uncertain.

They do not come from any single sector or ideology. They work across healthcare, education, ecology, justice, urban governance, livelihoods and inclusion. Many work in conditions that are punishing—remote geographies, fragile ecosystems, overburdened public systems, marginalised communities, chronic underfunding. Yet they deliver results, big or small.

So, if Aravind Eye Hospital in Madurai does not treat scale as a threat to quality, Pune-based Aaji Care refuses to expand faster than quality allows. Aravind was founded in 1976 by Dr Govindappa Venkataswamy, and grew from an 11-bed clinic into a globally respected eyecare system that performs hundreds of thousands of surgeries every year. Nearly half its patients receive free or highly subsidised care. Yet the institution maintains clinical standards that rival the best hospitals in the world.

Spanning fields as diverse as healthcare and ecology, these are practical efforts to solve problems that are most entrenched in our country

Aaji Care emerged from a more personal crisis. When Prasad Bhide's mother was bedridden for months, he saw how fragile India's eldercare arrangements were. His response was structural: professional caregiver training, assisted-living centres for dementia, post-operative and palliative care. Aaji Care is not only a service provider. It also seeks to dispel the unease that shadows families who seek outside help.

Other transformations unfold outside institutions. In Gujarat's Amreli district, Savjibhai Dholakia revived groundwater through rainwater harvesting, restoring agriculture and livelihoods. In Telangana, Narsanna and Padma Koppula have demonstrated that regenerative farming can be both productive and resilient. In Gurugram, ecologist Vijay Dhasmana restored a wasteland—an abandoned mine, at that—into the Aravalli Biodiversity Park by scrupulously planting native trees. Today, it supports hundreds of plant species and significant wildlife, while serving as a reference point for urban ecological restoration.

Justice, too, is being quietly shored up. The Majlis Legal Centre for Women and Children, founded by Flavia Agnes in 1991, recognised that survivors of violence needed empathetic legal help, and not a system that caused further harm. By combining individual legal aid with training and policy reform, Majlis helped reshape courtroom procedures. In Assam, UTSAH worked with the police—not against them—to institutionalise child-friendly policing through the Assam Police Sishu Mitra Programme.

Collectively, these initiatives form a Force for Good, a constellation of change-makers working quietly across India. Driven by the pursuit of positive change, they are shaped by a vision in which prosperity, social welfare and environmental responsibility are not competing goals, but mutually reinforcing ones. They are shining examples of how to transform the Republic: by helping others to help themselves. ■